

(2) Anabaptism

BRIEF INTRODUCTION

The Anabaptist church (Anabaptism) is a Protestant denomination with approximately 3-4 million (2014 estimates) members (often called anabaptist) worldwide. Anabaptism is the fruit of a early 16th century (1522-1525 CE) movement known as Radical Reformation (considered offshoot of Protestant Reformation) that disagreed with Luther and Zwingli on host of issues most importantly of that of infant Baptism. They viewed baptism was to be performed on believing adults only.

Conrad Grebel, George Blaurock and Felix Mantz (according majority view) are credited as the founder of the movement whose reform began in Zurich, Switzerland between 1522-1525 CE. The term "Anabaptism" (literally means rebaptism or baptized again) was initially used by the opponents of the Radical Reformation and later adopted for their own name. From there the movement spread to parts of Germany, Moravia and other parts of Europe. Anabaptists were heavily persecuted early on (during 16th and 17th century) by both Roman Catholics and Protestants.

By the end of 17th century the leading Anabaptists groups were the Mennonites, Hutterites, Bretheren and the Amish. Mennonites were named after the leader of the movement Menno Simons (1496-1561) in Netherlands. Followers of Swiss bishop named Jakob Amman (1656-1730) who led a movement for reform within the church resulting in schism and formation of a new group name Amish. Members of these groups brought their faith when they migrated to North America.

In our following discussion we will focus only on unique aspects of Anabaptism and where there are differences with other Protestant denominations. So it is important to read upon 'Branches of Christianity' and 'Protestantism' in our website before proceeding any further.

SOURCES OF RELIGIOUS/SACRED INFORMATION

Anabaptists (like all other Protestant denominations) only considers the holy Bible as the source of religious/sacred information.

KEY FEATURES OF BELIEF

(Only the unique features of Anabaptism are discussed in this section)

Baptism: Anabaptists do not baptize infants and children. They believe Baptism is only for believing adults. They believe that a person must first believe before he could be accepted into the Church with the sign of water baptism. They also believe to baptize one doesn't have to be an ordained minister.

Lord's Supper: Anabaptists view on Lord's Supper (occasionally called the "fellowship at the Lord's Table") is more of symbolic nature which was simply memorial in which Christ was in no way present in the elements.

Pacifism: Anabaptists believe one must not use violence or force to obtain or protect his rights. Most Anabaptists opposed to all military service, and took no oaths and held no government offices.

Separation of church and state: Anabaptists believe in absolute separation of Church and state from the movement's conception. They believe church represents the community of saved and state (civil government) belongs to the world. They didn't want either element to influence the other.

FOR MORE INFORMATION (Some Sources Used For This Article)

http://thirdmill.org/newfiles/jac_arnold/ch.arnold.rmt.10.html,
<http://www.anabaptistchurch.org/>,
<http://www.anabaptists.org/>
<http://www.patheos.com/Library/Anabaptist>,
<http://www.anabaptistnetwork.com/node/467>